cent in 2017), model schools in all districts and free health insurance for the entire population. "Our health insurance scheme was launched even before the Centre's Ayushman Bharat (2018). Enrolment in government schools has jumped by 230 per cent in the past five years," claims Biren Singh.

Unemployment, though, is a major issue in Manipur. At over 9 per cent, it's the second highest in the northeast. With few industries, most youngsters in this poor state, which accounts for 0.16 per cent of India's GDP and has a per

HIGH SPIRITS NPP leader Yumnam Joykumar Singh and daughter Ratika Yumnam (left); NPF candidate Ram Muivah campaigns in Ukhrul



capita income half the national average, depend on government jobs. However, government hiring stopped when the pandemic broke out. Several examinations for government positions were conducted but results withheld. "If we return to power, all results will be immediately declared," says Biren Singh.

The CM claims the government's support has helped launch 5,400 startups and 11,000 MSME units in Manipur—primarily in agriculture, horticulture, handloom and handicrafts—and created about 100,000 jobs. Manipur has the highest number of handicraft units in the northeast. Handloom is the largest cottage industry and the state ranks among the top five in the country in terms of the number of looms. It also accounts for 14 per cent of India's bamboo production.

CONGRESS EYES A COMEBACK

The Congress accuses the BJP government of making false promises. The party says the Modi government's Act East policy has failed to boost cross-border trade in the northeast. Manipur is considered India's gateway to the east through Moreh, which is the only feasible land route for trade between India, Myanmar and South Asia. "Except propaganda and lies, the central government has done nothing. Union ministers visited Manipur but no development package was announced," says the Congress's Ibobi Singh, who was chief minister from 2002 to 2017.

BOTH THE BJP AND CONGRESS, FEARING MORE INFIGHTING, HAVE REFRAINED FROM OFFICIALLY DECLARING THEIR CHIEF MINISTERIAL CANDIDATES

The Congress manifesto promises 50,000 jobs every year, 33 per cent reservation for women in government jobs, increase in rice production, control on price rise, and creating a 'mountain economy' for integrated development of land and people in the hills. The 73-year-old Ibobi Singh is once again leading the Congress's campaign to regain its electoral space in Manipur. The single largest party in 2017 with 28 seats, the Congress has lost 15 MLAs in the past five years, including state unit president Govindas Konthoujam Singh, to poaching by the BJP. Congress insiders allege that the large-scale defections happened because of Ibobi Singh's excessive grip on the party organisation and reluctance to let other leaders grow. Biren Singh too had left the Congress in 2016, following a tiff with Ibobi.

The heaviest damage to the Congress was perhaps inflicted by Imo Singh, son of former CM Rajkumar Jaichandra Singh and son-in-law of Biren Singh. Ignored by Ibobi in party affairs, Imo allegedly facilitated the defection of Congress MLAs to the BJP—most recently of Haokip. During a no-confidence motion in 2020, he saved the Biren Singh government by getting six Congress MLAs to resign and two to abstain. Imo Singh eventually joined the BJP in November last year.

Several Congress leaders are wary of Ibobi Singh's 'anti-Naga' image. In 2010, his government did not allow T. Muivah to visit his home in Ukhrul. In spite of that, the Congress won nine of the 20 hill seats, including Ukhrul, in 2017—the highest among all parties. It only showed that candidates' victory or defeat in elections in Manipur was not determined much by their party.

Bhakta Charan Das, the AICC (All India Congress Committee) in-charge for Manipur, claims defections have helped his party. "We are united and have the opportunity to field good candidates who are committed to the party ideology and people's welfare," says Das. Congress state chief N. Loken Singh is confident that the party will form the government on its own. Despite the display of unity, the Congress has shied away from declaring a chief ministerial candidate. Das, though, says Ibobi Singh should be the natural choice.

The BJP has its own worries over who will be chief minister should the party return to power. If it fails to get a majority on its own, the party will look to Imo Singh for help, as he still has friends in the Congress. The BJP may also have to depend on Govindas Singh, who also has extensive links in the Congress. But he may demand the CM's chair in return. The BJP has other aspirants too, such as Thongam Biswajit Singh.

Union minister Bhupender Yadav recently announced in Imphal that the BJP parliamentary board will take the final call on the chief minister should the party get a majority. His statement has led to speculation that the BJP